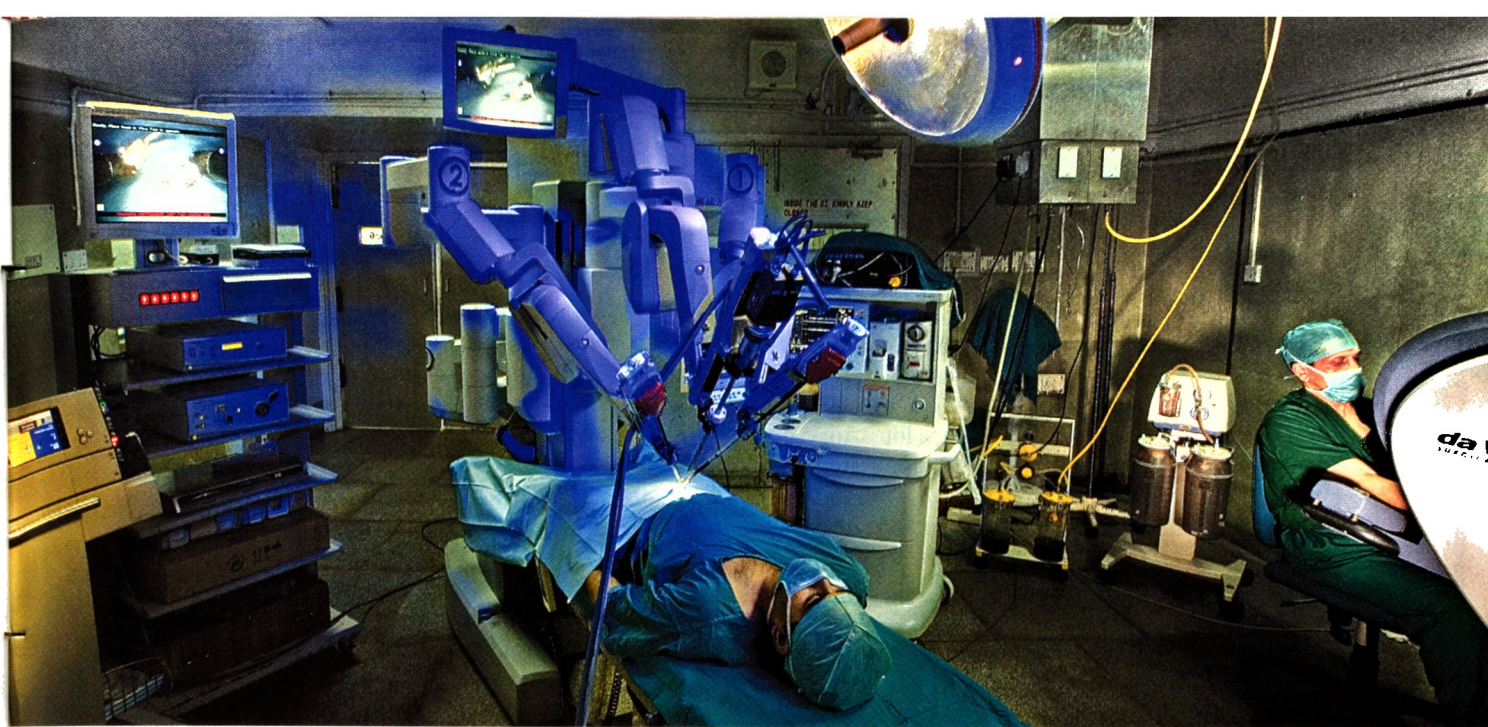




BANDEEP SINGH

INDIA TOMORROW

HEALTHCARE AND TECHNOLOGY

The Wealth of WELLNESS

India has to merge medicine with its strengths in technology to improve accessibility and affordability

By **SHILADITYA SENGUPTA**

Imagine a chip that is implanted in the brain which processes images from an artificial retina grafted in the eye and restores vision in a blind person. Or imagine a nanoparticle that packs in a pharmacy and can deliver small bursts of combinations of medicines exactly at the desired site in the body to cure cancer without any side-effects. This is the future of medicine that is being realised today in the leading universities of the world. It cannot happen in a single laboratory, but through the collaboration between an electronics engineer, a computer scientist and an ophthalmologist in the case of the artificial eye, or a chemist, a bio-engineer, a biologist and a clinician working

together on nanomedicine. The future of medical cures lies at the interface of technology. Is India there today? No. Can it get there? Absolutely yes. After all, 'Technology Leapfrogging' is a term coined to define India's progress in the technology sector, and there is no reason why we will not see similar leapfrogging in delivering innovations for healthcare. When I look at India, I don't see what doesn't exist—I see the tremendous possibilities that can make it happen.

Our biggest assets are the technology leaders of tomorrow being produced in our engineering institutes, some of the finest chemists being trained at our national laboratories, and some passionate clinicians and biologists in our bio-medical schools. However, we need to realise that our academic institutions should not be just about education but should foster an environment for creativity, i.e. we need innovation universities that create thought leaders, not followers. This can be achieved when these